

Yanjun Chen

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Making the environment trainable, the way models are: measuring what each piece (reward models, verifiers, curricula) contributes to the model it trains, across reinforcement learning, large language models, and embodied AI.

EDUCATION

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University, Hong Kong Sept 2024 to present
PhD, Department of Computing. Candidature confirmed June 2026; thesis *Towards Efficient Reinforcement Learning via Environment Measurement and Shaping*.
Advisors: Prof. Wenjie Li (Maggie), Prof. Wei Zhang.

Jinan University, Guangzhou, China Sept 2020 to Jun 2024
B.Eng. in Cyberspace Security. GPA 88.6 / 100 · Rank 6 of 62 · Outstanding Graduate.

PUBLICATIONS

Yanjun Chen = author; ☆ = first author; venues in italic.

In submission

1. ☆ **Yanjun Chen**, Yirong Sun, Hanlin Wang, Jinghan Wang, Xinming Zhang, Xiaoyu Shen, Wenjie Li, Wei Zhang. Exact Is Easier: Credit Assignment for Cooperative LLM Agents. *arXiv:2603.06859*, 2026.

Peer-reviewed

1. Xinghao Chen, Zhixin Sun, Wenjin Guo, Miao Zhang, **Yanjun Chen**, Yirong Sun, Hao Su, Yu Pan, et al. Unveiling the Key Factors for Distilling Chain-of-Thought Reasoning. *Findings of ACL 2025*.
2. Yirong Sun, Dawei Zhu, **Yanjun Chen**, Eric Xiao, Xinghao Chen, Xiaoyu Shen. Fine-Grained and Multi-Dimensional Metrics for Document-Level Machine Translation. *NAACL 2025*.
3. ☆ **Yanjun Chen**, Dawei Zhu, Yirong Sun, Xinghao Chen, Wei Zhang, Xiaoyu Shen. The Accuracy Paradox in RLHF: When Better Reward Models Don't Yield Better Language Models. *EMNLP 2024*.

Preprints (co-author)

1. Xinghao Chen, Anhao Zhao, Heming Xia, Xuan Lu, Hanlin Wang, **Yanjun Chen**, Wei Zhang, Jian Wang, Wenjie Li, et al. Reasoning Beyond Language: A Comprehensive Survey on Latent Chain-of-Thought Reasoning. *arXiv:2505.16782*, 2025.

HONORS & AWARDS

May 2026 PolyU Micro Fund 2025/26 Cohort 2, shortlisted (HK\$20,000 cash prize).
May 2026 HKSTP Ideation Programme, conditional offer.
Jun 2024 Outstanding Graduate, School of Information Science & Technology, Jinan University.
2022-23 Undergraduate competition prizes in data mining, mathematical modeling, and blockchain.

OPEN SOURCE

AccuracyParadox-RLHF, author / maintainer
Official implementation of *The Accuracy Paradox in RLHF* (EMNLP 2024). Reproducible training pipelines, evaluation harnesses, and reference reward models. github.com/Battam1111/AccuracyParadox-RLHF

TEACHING & SERVICE

Teaching (TA) COMP5221 Software Project Management (2025/26 S2) · COMP1002 Computational Thinking and Problem Solving (2025/26 S1) · COMP1411 Introduction to Computer Systems (2024/25 S2) · COMP5567 Distributed Algorithms and Protocols for Blockchains (2024/25 S1).

Reviewing ACL ARR 2026 (March and May cycles) · IEEE Transactions on Neural Networks and Learning Systems (TNNLS), invited.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming Python, C/C++, Bash; Git, Linux.
Frameworks PyTorch, Hugging Face Transformers / TRL / Datasets.
Languages Mandarin (native), English (professional), Japanese (elementary).